

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Consulting English

Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For management consultants, strategy consultants, implementation consultants, analysts, engagement managers, client partners, internal consultants, and advisory teams.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

adoption

The extent to which people begin and continue using a product or process.

assumption

Something treated as true for planning or reasoning, though it may need verification.

change management

Helping people and organizations adopt a new way of working.

change request

A proposal to alter an agreed product, scope, schedule, or process.

confidentiality

Protecting information from disclosure to people who are not authorized to receive it.

data request

A request for defined information for a stated purpose.

deadline

The latest agreed or required time for completing an action.

decision ask

A clear statement of the decision requested from an audience.

decision question

The specific choice or issue that an analysis needs to help resolve.

decision rights

The allocation of authority to recommend, approve, or make particular decisions.

discovery

The process of learning needs or facts; in litigation, formal exchange of relevant information.

evidence plan

A plan identifying what information is needed and how it will be obtained or assessed.

hypothesis

A proposed explanation or prediction that can be examined using evidence.

implementation constraint

A condition that limits how a proposed change can be put into practice.

issue tree

A structured breakdown of a question into smaller issues for analysis.

iteration

A repeated cycle of developing, reviewing, and improving work.

next step

The specific action that should follow the current discussion or stage.

operating model

How work is organized across people, process, technology, governance, and metrics.

option set

The alternatives being considered for a decision.

owner

Named person or role accountable for a decision, action, deliverable, or risk.

problem statement

A clear description of the issue to be addressed and why it matters.

recommendation

A proposed action supported by reasons and relevant evidence.

risk

Uncertainty that may affect objectives or expose people or assets to harm or loss.

scope

Defined boundary of work, responsibility, deliverables, assumptions, and exclusions.

so what

An informal prompt asking why a finding matters for the audience's decision.

stakeholder

Person or group with an interest, risk, authority, or dependency in the work.

stakeholder buy-in

Support from people whose participation or approval affects an initiative.

statement of work

A document defining the work, deliverables, responsibilities, and relevant commercial conditions of an engagement.

steering committee

A group that oversees an initiative and resolves major direction or governance questions.

storyline

The ordered sequence of claims and supporting points in a presentation or narrative.

tradeoff

A choice that improves one objective while giving up something on another.

workstream

A connected set of activities within a larger project.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Ask a precise question

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Match certainty to evidence

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Ask for an actionable next step

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Make a complex point clear

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Offer a workable tradeoff

We can ..., provided that

Would you prefer ... or ...?

I can take that proposal for review; I cannot yet confirm

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

Repair a misunderstanding

My earlier message did not make ... clear.

I'm sorry for The correct information is

Let me check that the revised explanation addresses

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

Give feedback people can use

In [specific situation], I noticed

The effect was What was happening from your perspective?

Could we agree to ... and review it ...?

Use a specific example instead of a personality label. Explain its effect, invite the person's perspective, and agree on a practical improvement. Focus on communication that can be changed, not accent or national identity.

Help a group reach a clear next step

Let's hear ... before we decide.

The point we still need to resolve is

Who will make this decision, and what do they need?

Summarize the issue neutrally, invite missing perspectives, and distinguish discussion from decision. State who can decide and record any unresolved question. Do not assume silence means agreement.

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Client Discovery and Problem Definition

A client requests a benchmarking study but actually needs to decide whether to centralize a service.

What decision will the benchmark help you make? If the question is centralization, we should examine the criteria and constraints first, then decide which external comparisons would be useful.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

02 | Hypotheses and Issue Trees

A team believes customer churn is caused by price but has not examined service experience or competitor changes.

Price is one hypothesis, not an established explanation. I'll structure the work around the main alternatives and identify the evidence that would support or weaken each one.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

03 | Data Requests and Client Burden

A client receives a 40-item data request with one deadline. Only six items are needed for the first analysis.

Could we prioritize the six items needed for the first analysis and agree on their owners? I'll explain their purpose and propose later dates for the remaining requests to reduce unnecessary burden.

Try it again: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

04 | Slide Storylines and Executive Synthesis

A presentation has twelve charts and no clear recommendation. The audience must decide whether to pilot a new process.

I'll lead with the pilot recommendation and the decision required, then use the strongest evidence and its limitations to support it. The remaining charts can answer follow-up questions.

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

05 | Scope Management and Change Requests

A client requests a second market study halfway through an engagement. The existing schedule covers only the original market.

We can assess the additional market as a scope change. Would you prefer to extend the schedule, add resources, or reprioritize the original work? I'll prepare the implications for discussion.

Try it again: The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

06 | Difficult Client Feedback

A client says a recommendation ignores a staffing constraint that the team missed in discovery.

You're right that the recommendation does not account for that staffing constraint. Let's confirm its effect and revise the options. I'll make the changed assumption explicit in the next version.

Try it again: The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

07 | Implementation and Change Management

Managers are expected to adopt a new process but have not received training or time to practice.

The rollout asks managers to change their work without enough preparation. Could we add role-specific training and a short practice period, then check where adoption is difficult?

Try it again: The recipient disagrees with your interpretation. Return to the observed example, listen, and revise an unsupported assumption.

08 | Steering Committees and Final Readouts

A steering group agrees on the problem but is split between two options. The presentation time is almost over.

Let's pause the slides and compare the two options against the agreed criteria. Then we can record the decision, or the precise unresolved question and who will resolve it by when.

Try it again: A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.